

Lobe-finned fish

Instead of using their fins for steering, the members of this fish family began using them to “walk” into crevices in reefs and to push themselves along the seafloor. As the years passed, their fins became stockier and muscular—they were beginning to turn into legs. Called the “lobe-finned fish,” these fish were the first vertebrates to crawl out of water and begin to live on land.



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Stocky, rounded (lobe-shaped) fins supported by bones
- Gills to breathe in water
- Some also had lunglike air chambers to breathe air

When

These fish appeared in the Ordovician Period (505–440 million years ago). Many died out at the end of the Cretaceous Period, 65 million years ago, but lobe-finned fish still exist today.

Eusthenopteron

YOOS-then-OP-ter-on



- **When** 385 million years ago (Late Devonian)
- **Fossil location** N. America, Greenland, Scotland, Latvia, Estonia
- **Habitat** Oceans
- **Length** 5 ft (1.5 m)



Like most fish, *Eusthenopteron* was covered in scales and had fins. However, the bones supporting its fins were similar to those of the first amphibians (animals that live partly in water and partly on land). A predator, *Eusthenopteron* may have lurked in clumps of seaweed, waiting to ambush passing prey.

Panderichthys

PAN-der-ICK-this



- **When** 400 million years ago (Late Devonian)
- **Fossil location** Latvia, Lithuania, Estonia, Russia
- **Habitat** Oceans
- **Length** 5 ft (1.5 m)

Even though *Panderichthys* (right) was a fish, it may have been able to climb on to land, propping itself on its front fins for just a moment. It had fins in pairs and scales all over its body, like fish today. However, its fins were supported by bones similar to those of an amphibian's. It breathed through its gills underwater, but an opening on top of its head, probably connected to a lunglike air chamber, allowed it to breathe on land as well.



▲ FISH OUT OF WATER

Panderichthys was like an amphibian in some ways. Although its body was long and slender, its head was wide and flattened with large eyes on top, giving it a froglike face.

Tiktaalik

tik-TAA-lick



- **When** Nearly 380 million years ago (Late Devonian)
- **Fossil location** Canada
- **Habitat** Shallow seas
- **Length** 3 ft (1 m)

This strange creature (right) was like a cross between a fish and a salamander. It had a flat head with eyes on top—perhaps for peeping above the water's surface—and a neck joint that allowed it to turn its head. Its “fins” had wrist and shoulder joints and even simple fingers. *Tiktaalik* couldn't truly walk, but it could probably wriggle out of water and use the fins to prop itself up.

